Xi heads for fourth term as centralization deepens

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【メール原文】

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Next leadership cycle will harden centralization around Xi

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Eurasia Group assesses a 95% likelihood that the 21st Party Congress in late 2027 will grant Xi Jinping a fourth term as the general secretary of the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) and leader of the military, with a pro forma confirmation in early 2028 extending his tenure as president.
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There is no credible opposition to Xi, no sign he intends to relinquish any of his three core roles, and no evidence to support speculation that he is facing significant health issues.
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The lack of succession planning heading into the Party Congress is a strategic choice, and expected personnel changes in 2027 are likely to reaffirm Xi-centered governance.

Xi still dominates China’s political system. The Politburo continues to handle major decisions, including on economic policy, strategic technologies, national security matters, and the 15th Five-Year Plan. The State Council, as the executive arm of government, operates with little real autonomy. In foreign affairs, Xi, Foreign Minister Wang Yi, and Vice Premier He Lifeng remain the dominant actors, while other senior leaders have scant visibility or policy influence in this area. While formal institutions still convene and execute policy, Xi remains the sole center of political authority.

Recent personnel moves point to Beijing’s preference for control and stability ahead of the Party Congress. Since our last review of party developments in September, Beijing has continued to reshuffle provincial party secretaries at a steady pace, with the number of newly appointed provincial chiefs at 15 out of 31. A parallel process is underway with the military. The Central Military Commission (CMC) is closing out its last batch of major corruption cases. The leadership has shifted its focus to discipline and control rather than transition.

The lack of a succession plan ahead of the 21st Party Congress is intentional. Xi has shown little interest in designating an heir, and no figure has accumulated the cross-institutional profile, political sponsorship, or implicit endorsement that has historically preceded elevation to the top (see: note 31 July 2025). This is by design, with Xi continuing to run a system in which meaningful advancement

depends on his explicit backing.

2027 will likely bring personnel turnover while preserving Xi's dominance. Most members of the Politburo Standing Committee (PSC) will face the informal retirement threshold by the next Party Congress. Xi has already shown that he can override that norm for himself while applying it selectively to others. Under the informal "seven up, eight down" convention, officials who are 67 or younger at the time of a Party Congress can remain in office, while those who are 68 or older typically retire.

Li Qiang, Zhao Leji, Wang Huning, Cai Qi, and Li Xi could therefore face pressure to leave the PSC. Even so, any reshuffle would more likely refresh the lineup than alter the system's basic structure. Xi has shown no interest in using the Party Congress to step back from any of his three core roles—CCP Central Committee general secretary, PRC president, and CMC chairman. Giving up any one of those positions would create ambiguity over where authority rests. Xi has spent the past decade eliminating that ambiguity, and he has no interest in reviving it.

Xi’s dominance leaves the system vulnerable to decision-making bottlenecks, rather than opening an alternative route for policy change. The same structure that blocks alternative power centers also suppresses initiative elsewhere in the system. When major decisions must pass through a single political node, Beijing gains tighter control but loses speed and flexibility in routine governance. If anything were to interfere with the level of time and attention Xi can devote to his duties, this bottleneck factor would raise the risk of system delays just as faster responses are needed.

There is no evidence to support speculation about Xi’s health and capacity to lead. We are unaware of any credible basis for claims of serious ailments, and Beijing has not acknowledged recent questions raised in the media. Xi is a 73-year-old leader managing the extraordinary strain of leading one of the world’s most powerful countries at a challenging time. Any normal age-related limitations could carry wider political significance when so much decision-making depends on one person. While this risk exists for any leader in this age bracket, there is no indication that Xi is currently facing such challenges.

If there were a crisis of leadership, the PSC possesses institutional capacity and credibility to manage the situation. It holds the main levers of party, government, and military coordination. China might face a period of contested positioning within the top leadership if succession suddenly became an issue, but the hardwired preference for stability in the system would likely favor continuity.

The 26-29 October 5th Plenum will reinforce Xi-centered governance. The meeting will further shift concentrated rule from political practice into institutional guidance and party doctrine. The central question ahead of the 21st Party Congress is therefore not whether the system will remain centralized—it will. The more important question is how rigidly the party will formalize that structure.

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